Terracotta

Light + dark · accent #b86a3d · WCAG AA

9:41

Mesopotamia

6 CH

Iraq's first cities and cuneiform

‹ Bronze Age Collapse

Ancient Egypt ›

01 **The Land Between Two Rivers**

Geographic and cultural setting

5000
500 BCE

READ THE FULL CHAPTER

The Land Between Two Rivers

Chapter 1 · 9 events · 5000 – 500 BCE

SUMMARY · FOR REVIEW

Southern Iraq has no stone, no metal ore, no decent timber, and barely any rain — by every obvious measure, it should be a terrible place to live.

What it does have is silt: every spring, the Tigris and Euphrates dump fine fertile soil across the floodplain as they melt out of the Anatolian mountains, leaving some of the richest farmland on earth.

The catch is that controlling that water requires canals dug by hundreds of laborers, maintained for generations — which means you need organization before you can have a harvest.

Mesopotamia is what happened when a desperate people built bureaucracy to eat.

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Lapis

Light + dark · accent #2f6bc4 · WCAG AA

9:41

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Aubergine

Light + dark · accent #7a4fbd · WCAG AA

9:41

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Old Gold

Light + dark · accent #a87725 · WCAG AA

9:41

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Verdigris

Light + dark · accent #2f8560 · WCAG AA

9:41

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